Ahmedabad-Bhuj-Vighakot Fort



SURESH NARAYANAN

Dasada, a town that sits on the edge of the Little Rann, is a hub of adventure. There are flamingos, deer and black buck to see at the Wild Ass sanctuary. From Wankaner to Gondal and Junagadh, there are palaces and car collections to delight in, but then we would be digressing from our route that is headed to the white Rann beyond Bhuj at Dhordo. This region also boasts some sites associated with the ancient Indus Valley civilisation. The BSF war memorial beyond the India Bridge is where civilians are usually stopped, but if you get permits, then you can make it to Vighakot Fort.



Kochi-Munnar-Thekaddy-Alappuzha

From the tea gardens around Munnar to the spice gardens around Thekaddy, from the backwaters of Alappuzha to Fort Kochi, there are many destinations dotted along this path. You could also visit the Periyar Tiger Reserve and spend time on a houseboat on the backwaters, but this route is not off-the-beaten track at all.

Vishakapatnam-Araku Valley-Jagdalpur

One can either start at Raipur or Hyderabad for this circuit, but I'd pick Chhattisgarh. The state remains one of the last bastions not yet overtaken by development, although the beautiful Araku Valley now has a constant stream of tourists. The coffee stalls around the plantations in the valley offer an overly sweet heady concoction while the numerous roadside eateries offer a specialty—chicken cooked in bamboo in open fires. The entire route, with its side excursions, is pretty and also pristine.





Gangtok-Nathula-Zuluk-Kalimpong

Sikkim is untouched by heavy tourism and I have chosen the route from Nathula, via Nathang to Kalimpong, because of the switchbacks at Zuluk. The only place in India that rivals these is in Ladakh, on the way to Bara-lacha la. Apart from the trade that flourishes between India and China at Nathula, there are spots from where one can get great views of the Kanchenjunga.

Mumbai-Goa



This is one route that has been on the driver's map for as long as there have been road trips in India, but it can always be done with a twist. If you follow the straight road, then there are numerous beach towns to visit. Alternatively, you can just hug the beach from Alibaug onwards and visit some famous and many unknown beaches nestled between the outcrops of the Western Ghats. The other way to do it is to drive towards Pune and choose one of the countless crossings over the Ghats.



SURESH NARAYANAN

Pasighat-Gelling

The beauty and the challenge of this drive is that one follows the Brahmaputra north to nearly the point where it enters India from China. For the most part, one can drive up the west bank of the river, and on the way back, cross over to the east bank where there are bigger towns like Yingkiong and better roads as well. It may be a better idea to use a 4x4, especially if you are planning to make this trip around the monsoon season.